

The Loyola Index Family: What a Degree-Imbalance Coordinate Can and Cannot Resolve

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Abstract

The two-parameter Gutman–Milovanović family $M_{\alpha,\beta}(G) = \sum_{uv \in E(G)} (d_u d_v)^\alpha (d_u + d_v)^\beta$ unifies the Zagreb, Randić, sum-connectivity and related degree-based indices. We study its normalized degree-imbalance exponential extension, the *Loyola index family*

$$LO(G; \alpha, \beta, \gamma) = \sum_{uv \in E(G)} (d_u d_v)^\alpha (d_u + d_v)^\beta \exp\left(\gamma \frac{|d_u - d_v|}{d_u + d_v}\right),$$

with $LO(G; \alpha, \beta, 0) = M_{\alpha,\beta}(G)$ identically.

We characterise what the imbalance coordinate can and cannot resolve. The family factorises into a degree-sum (scale) and a degree-ratio (shape) coordinate; on the resulting ratio plane the pure- γ points separate exactly the histograms of edge imbalances (for algebraic $\gamma \neq 0$). These histograms coincide with degree-pair profiles on trees up to order 12 (order 15 for $\Delta \leq 4$), so there the pure- γ points attain the discrimination limit of all vertex-degree-based indices, and they provably lose information beyond it. We

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also bound the number of γ -crossings of two graphs and characterise per-graph identifiability. The predictive result is negative: an apparent vaporization-enthalpy gain on the octanes and nonanes vanishes when the parent family is searched over a box that does not truncate it (a post hoc analysis), pre-registered tests on measured boiling points (34 decanes; 100 alkanes C6–C10, adjusted for size) find no demonstrated benefit from γ , and ridge regression on the degree-pair counts outperforms every single index. Hence γ is an interpretable, analytically tractable direction, not a predictive upgrade.

1 Introduction

Degree-based topological indices form one of the most developed descriptor classes of chemical graph theory, from the Randić and Zagreb indices [15, 28] and their parametric extensions, the general Randić and sum-connectivity families [5, 36], to the Sombor family and its many variants (see the survey [12]). Extremal results on bond-incident-degree (BID) indices are surveyed in [1], and a finite-dimensional linear framework for such indices is developed in [26].

The two-parameter unification of the product-based and sum-based degree indices is the *Gutman–Milovanović family*, introduced in [14] and studied in the recent bounds and QSPR literature [11, 21, 24]: $M_{\alpha,\beta}(G) = \sum_{uv \in E(G)} (d_u d_v)^\alpha (d_u + d_v)^\beta$, $\alpha, \beta \in \mathbb{R}$. Its special cases (catalogued in [21]) include the first and second Zagreb indices $M_{0,1} = M_1$ and $M_{1,0} = M_2$, the hyper-Zagreb index $M_{0,2} = HM$ [31], the modified second Zagreb index $M_{-1,0} = {}^mM_2$, the Randić index $M_{-1/2,0} = R$, the sum-connectivity index $M_{0,-1/2} = \chi$ [35], the harmonic index $2M_{0,-1} = H$, the inverse sum indeg index $M_{1,-1} = ISI$, the geometric–arithmetic index $2M_{1/2,-1} = GA$ [33], the arithmetic–geometric index $\frac{1}{2}M_{-1/2,1} = AG$, and, as parameter axes, the general Randić family $R_\alpha = M_{\alpha,0}$ and the general sum-connectivity family $\chi_\beta = M_{0,\beta}$. Parameter-optimized versions of this family have already been fitted to octane properties [2]; no novelty is claimed here for the backbone, its reduction catalogue or its tunability.

In this paper we study a three-parameter extension of $M_{\alpha,\beta}$, the *Loyola index family*, obtained by attaching a separately parameterized expo-

nential factor in the normalized degree imbalance $q_{uv} = |d_u - d_v|/(d_u + d_v)$ of each edge: $LO(G; \alpha, \beta, \gamma) = \sum_{uv} (d_u d_v)^\alpha (d_u + d_v)^\beta e^{\gamma q_{uv}}$, so that $LO(G; \alpha, \beta, 0) = M_{\alpha, \beta}(G)$ identically. Positive γ exponentially upweights degree-imbalanced edges, negative γ downweights them, and on regular graphs γ has no effect. The questions this paper answers are therefore about γ alone: is the imbalance direction mathematically independent of the parent parameters, what analytic structure does it carry, and does it add measurable structural or predictive information beyond an optimized Gutman–Milovanović parent?

Writing the summand as $\exp(\alpha \ln(d_u d_v) + \beta \ln(d_u + d_v) + \gamma q_{uv})$ shows that the family is a three-parameter subfamily of the exponential vertex-degree-based indices of Rada [25], whose extremal theory is developed in [10, 16, 32]; no extremal-ordering result is claimed here. Published one-parameter exponential indices (e.g. [7, 8]) place their parameter on a single classical generator inside the exponent; here the two Gutman–Milovanović basis terms act as the factors $(d_u d_v)^\alpha (d_u + d_v)^\beta$ while the imbalance coordinate carries its own parameter γ . The imbalance ratio itself is not new: it appears in the diminished Sombor index [22], in the irregularity index $IRLA(G) = 2 \sum_{uv} q_{uv}$ [29] (of which the pure- γ point $LO(G; 0, 0, \gamma) = \sum_{uv} e^{\gamma q_{uv}}$ is the exponential index in the sense of [25]), in degree-ratio indices [13, 23], and in the parent family itself, since $1 - q_{uv}^2 = 4d_u d_v / (d_u + d_v)^2$ gives $M_{\alpha, -2\alpha}(G) = 4^{-\alpha} \sum_{uv} (1 - q_{uv}^2)^\alpha$. What is new is a coordinate *linear* in q_{uv} in the exponent, which, unlike $\ln(1 - q_{uv}^2)$, is not an affine function of $\ln(d_u d_v)$ and $\ln(d_u + d_v)$ once a vertex of degree at least 3 is admitted (Lemma 1, $\Delta \geq 3$). To our knowledge, and within the scope of the literature search documented in the reproducibility package, no published index couples it multiplicatively, with its own parameter, to the Gutman–Milovanović family. The exponential form is not derived from a physical model; it is chosen because it makes the family log-linear in its parameters, so that γ acts multiplicatively and only on irregularity and the whole family is an exponential family in (α, β, γ) , which is what makes the convexity, identifiability and discrimination results of Section 3 available.

On hydrogen-suppressed molecular graphs with $\Delta \leq 4$, every BID in-

dex is a linear functional of the ten edge-degree-pair counts $m_{ij}(G) = |\{uv \in E(G) : \{d_u, d_v\} = \{i, j\}\}|$, $1 \leq i \leq j \leq 4$ (cf. the linear framework of Rada [26]), so the Loyola family lies inside a fixed ten-dimensional descriptor space, however its parameters are chosen.

Scope of the contribution. Several of the mathematical results are applications of standard tools (the convexity of log-sum-exp functions, Laguerre’s rule of signs, the Lindemann–Weierstrass theorem and the minimality theory of exponential families); we claim no novelty for the tools, only for the structural characterisation that results. The family is not proposed for predictive superiority, which we do not find on the sets and protocols of Section 5; its interest lies in interpretability within the parent family (every member is a deformation of a classical index, recovered at $\gamma = 0$), the separate control of size and shape, the ratio-plane geometry it shares with GA and AG , and analytic tractability (log-linearity gives convexity, closed-form derivatives such as $\partial_\gamma \log LO = \mathbb{E}_\theta[q]$, and an exact identifiability theory); *IRLA* is, to first order in γ , a single slice of this structure. The QSPR datasets are small: 18 octanes, 35 nonanes, 34 decanes with usable measured boiling points, and 100 alkanes C6–C10 in a pooled size-adjusted set. We therefore present the chemometric component as diagnostic evidence about what imbalance information does and does not add to the parent family, not as proof of chemical predictive utility.

In sum, the contributions are: (i) the scale–shape factorisation and the ratio-plane theorem (Theorem 2), which characterises exactly what the pure- γ line can discriminate and is in large part a limitation result (tree collisions at every order from 13, from 16 for $\Delta \leq 4$); (ii) the crossing bound (Proposition 3, from Laguerre’s rule of signs) and per-graph identifiability (Proposition 4), the latter resting on an elementary independence lemma (Lemma 1); (iii) log-convexity with mean/covariance derivatives (Theorem 1, standard), closed forms and routine termwise bounds for $\gamma \geq 0$ (Supplementary Material); (iv) the degree-pair ceiling, an elementary observation that is realised on the octane benchmark (Proposition 6), and structure sensitivity; and (v) a negative, reproducible QSPR diagnostic: freeing γ gives no consistent gain once the parent’s search box does not truncate it, complemented by pre-registered tests on measured boil-

ing points of decanes and of pooled C6–C10 alkanes (Section 5.4), where ridge regression on the degree-pair counts is far ahead of every single index on the decanes and ahead on the pooled set. The family is offered as an analytically transparent, interpretable third direction on the Gutman–Milovanović parameter space, not as a better predictor.

2 Preliminaries

2.1 Notation

Let $G = (V, E)$ be a finite simple connected graph of order $n = |V|$ and size $m = |E|$. For a vertex $v \in V$, the degree $d_v = d_G(v)$ counts the edges incident to v . The maximum and minimum degrees are denoted $\Delta = \Delta(G)$ and $\delta = \delta(G)$. In the chemometric sections we work with hydrogen-suppressed molecular graphs, where the assumption $\Delta \leq 4$ holds for alkane carbon skeletons (all graphs analysed here) and for most organic molecules, but not universally: hypervalent centres such as phosphorus in PCl_5 (degree 5) or sulfur in pentafluorosulfanyl groups (degree 6) exceed it.

The classical graph families used are the complete graph K_n , the cycle C_n , the path P_n , the star S_n , the complete bipartite graph $K_{p,q}$, the hypercube Q_k (2^k vertices, $k \cdot 2^{k-1}$ edges, k -regular), the wheel W_n (an $(n-1)$ -cycle plus a universal vertex), the friendship graph F_p (p triangles sharing a common vertex), and the r -regular graphs. For an edge $e = uv \in E(G)$ we write (d_u, d_v) for its *degree pair*, understood as an unordered multiset $\{d_u, d_v\}$.

2.2 Definition

Definition 1 (Loyola index family). Let $G = (V, E)$ be a simple connected graph. For $\alpha, \beta, \gamma \in \mathbb{R}$, the *Loyola index family* is defined as,

$$LO(G; \alpha, \beta, \gamma) = \sum_{uv \in E(G)} (d_u d_v)^\alpha (d_u + d_v)^\beta \exp\left(\gamma \frac{|d_u - d_v|}{d_u + d_v}\right) \quad (1)$$

Equation (1) is well defined for all $\alpha, \beta \in \mathbb{R}$ on graphs without isolated vertices (so that $d_u, d_v \geq 1$ on every edge). The expression is invariant under permutations of (u, v) because $d_u d_v = d_v d_u$, $d_u + d_v = d_v + d_u$, and $|d_u - d_v| = |d_v - d_u|$; hence $LO(G; \alpha, \beta, \gamma)$ depends only on the multiset of unordered edge degree pairs of G . When $\gamma = 0$ the family reduces identically to the Gutman–Milovanović family [14, 21],

$$LO(G; \alpha, \beta, 0) = M_{\alpha, \beta}(G) = \sum_{uv \in E(G)} (d_u d_v)^\alpha (d_u + d_v)^\beta,$$

whose classical special cases are catalogued in the Introduction. Throughout, $q_{uv} = \text{imb}(d_u, d_v)$, where $\text{imb}(x, y) = |x - y|/(x + y)$, denotes the normalized degree imbalance of the edge uv ; positive γ exponentially up-weights degree-imbalanced edges, negative γ downweights them, and on regular graphs every $q_{uv} = 0$ so that γ has no effect and $LO(G; \alpha, \beta, \gamma) = M_{\alpha, \beta}(G)$ for all γ .

3 Parameter geometry and the role of the imbalance parameter

This section collects the structural results. Throughout, $z_{uv} = (\ln(d_u d_v), \ln(d_u + d_v), q_{uv})$ is the feature vector of the edge uv and $\theta = (\alpha, \beta, \gamma)$, so that $LO_G(\theta) = \sum_{uv \in E(G)} e^{\theta^\top z_{uv}}$. The independence result below is a short computation (almost any edge feature that is not log-linear in the degrees would pass the same test).

Lemma 1 (Affine independence of the imbalance direction). *Let $\Delta \geq 3$ and let $P_\Delta = \{(i, j) : 1 \leq i \leq j \leq \Delta\}$ be the admissible degree pairs. Then the augmented feature vectors $(1, \ln(ij), \ln(i + j), q_{ij})$, $(i, j) \in P_\Delta$, span $\mathbb{R}^4$. Consequently, if two parameter triples θ, θ' satisfy $e^{\theta^\top z} = c e^{\theta'^\top z}$ for some constant $c > 0$ and all $(i, j) \in P_\Delta$, then $\theta = \theta'$ and $c = 1$; in particular no choice of (α', β') and scaling constant reproduces the action of $\gamma \neq 0$ on all admissible degree pairs. For $\Delta = 2$ the span has dimension 3, and for $\Delta = 1$ (the single pair $(1, 1)$, augmented vector $(1, 0, \ln 2, 0)$) it has dimension 1; in both cases the conclusion fails.*

Proof. It suffices to show that q_{ij} is not an affine function of $(\ln(ij), \ln(i+j))$ on P_Δ ; the four pairs $(1, 1), (2, 2), (1, 2), (1, 3)$, all admissible once $\Delta \geq 3$, witness this. Suppose $q_{ij} = a + b \ln(ij) + c \ln(i+j)$ on these pairs. From $(1, 1)$ and $(2, 2)$, where $q = 0$: $a + c \ln 2 = 0$ and $a + (2b + 2c) \ln 2 = 0$, giving $a = -c \ln 2$ and $b = -c/2$. Substituting into the $(1, 2)$ and $(1, 3)$ equations gives $\frac{1}{3} = c(\ln 3 - \frac{3}{2} \ln 2)$ and $\frac{1}{2} = c(\ln 2 - \frac{1}{2} \ln 3)$; in particular $c \neq 0$. Three times the first minus twice the second gives $0 = c(4 \ln 3 - \frac{13}{2} \ln 2)$, hence $8 \ln 3 = 13 \ln 2$, i.e. $3^8 = 2^{13}$, which is false ($6561 \neq 8192$). Hence the augmented vectors have rank 4. If $e^{\theta^\top z} = c e^{\theta'^\top z}$ on P_Δ , then $(\theta - \theta')^\top z_{ij} = \ln c$ for all admissible pairs, i.e. $(\ln c, \theta' - \theta)$ is orthogonal to every augmented vector, so $\theta = \theta'$ and $c = 1$. For $\Delta = 2$ only the pairs $(1, 1), (1, 2), (2, 2)$ exist and a direct computation shows the augmented vectors have rank 3; for $\Delta = 1$ the single augmented vector has rank 1. $\blacksquare$

Remark 1 (Independence versus per-graph identifiability). Lemma 1 concerns the edge-weight *function* on the full admissible pair set, not every individual graph: on a single graph G some direction v satisfies $LO(G; \theta + tv) = e^{ct} LO(G; \theta)$ for all t unless the realised feature vectors z_{ij} affinely span $\mathbb{R}^3$ (Proposition 4); along such a direction the index only rescales. On a regular graph nothing about θ is identifiable beyond one linear functional; if the edges of G realise at most three affinely independent augmented vectors, some direction of θ — possibly the γ direction — is unidentifiable from $LO(G; \cdot)$ alone. The lemma guarantees that no such degeneracy is forced on the whole molecular class $\Delta \geq 3$: the family separates parameters as a family of descriptors, even though particular graphs may not.

The next result is the standard convexity of a log-sum-exp (log-partition) function, whose gradient and Hessian are the mean and covariance of the exponent’s feature vector under the induced weights; we state it for LO because these moments have a direct interpretation here and because strictness depends on the degree pairs that G realises.

Theorem 1 (Global log-convexity). *Fix a graph G with $m \geq 1$ edges and define $F_G(\theta) = \log LO_G(\theta)$ on $\mathbb{R}^3$. Let $\mathbb{E}_\theta$ and Cov_θ denote mean and covariance under the edge probability measure $w_{uv}(\theta) = e^{\theta^\top z_{uv}} / LO_G(\theta)$.*

Then F_G is convex, with

$$\nabla F_G(\theta) = \mathbb{E}_\theta[z], \quad \nabla^2 F_G(\theta) = \text{Cov}_\theta(z) \succeq 0.$$

In particular $\partial_\gamma F_G = \mathbb{E}_\theta[q] \in [0, 1)$ and $\partial_\gamma^2 F_G = \text{Var}_\theta(q) \geq 0$, so $\log LO$ is nondecreasing and convex in γ , strictly increasing in γ unless every edge of G joins vertices of equal degree. Moreover $\text{Var}_\theta(q) = 0$ at some (equivalently, every) θ if and only if q_{uv} is constant over the edges of G : this covers regular graphs ($q \equiv 0$), but also, e.g., (Δ, δ) -biregular graphs, on which every edge carries the same nonzero imbalance and $\log LO$ is affine and strictly increasing in γ . F_G is strictly convex if and only if the edge feature vectors $\{z_{uv}\}_{uv \in E}$ do not lie in a proper affine subspace of $\mathbb{R}^3$; on a regular graph $F_G(\theta) = \log m + \theta^\top z_0$ is affine and $\text{Cov}_\theta(z) = 0$.

The formulas follow by direct differentiation (exponential-family calculus; proof in Supplementary Section S9).

Theorem 1 places the family in the classical exponential-family framework: moving γ reweights the edge measure toward imbalanced edges at rate $\mathbb{E}_\theta[q]$, and the Cauchy–Schwarz midpoint inequality of Supplementary Section S9 is precisely midpoint log-convexity, i.e. a corollary of this theorem.

3.1 Size–shape factorisation, the ratio plane, crossings and identifiability

Since $4ij/(i+j)^2 = 1 - q_{ij}^2$, every admissible pair satisfies $\ln(ij) = 2 \ln(i+j) + \ln(1 - q_{ij}^2) - \ln 4$, and therefore

$$LO(G; \alpha, \beta, \gamma) = 4^{-\alpha} \sum_{uv \in E(G)} (d_u + d_v)^{2\alpha + \beta} (1 - q_{uv}^2)^\alpha e^{\gamma q_{uv}}. \quad (2)$$

The combination $\kappa = 2\alpha + \beta$ acts only on the edge degree sum (scale), while α and γ act only on q_{uv} , which is a function of the degree ratio alone (shape). Write $n_q(G)$ for the number of edges of G with $q_{uv} = q$ (the q -histogram), and $\Pi = \{(\alpha, \beta, \gamma) : \beta = -2\alpha\}$ for the plane $\kappa = 0$, which contains every pure- γ point $(0, 0, \gamma)$ as well as $GA = 2 LO(\frac{1}{2}, -1, 0)$ and

$$AG = \tfrac{1}{2}LO(-\tfrac{1}{2}, 1, 0).$$

Theorem 2 (Ratio plane). *Let G and H be graphs.*

- (i) *On Π , $LO(G; \alpha, -2\alpha, \gamma) = \sum_q n_q(G) \left((1 - q^2)/4\right)^\alpha e^{\gamma q}$ depends on G only through its q -histogram. G and H agree at every point of Π if and only if $n_q(G) = n_q(H)$ for all q ; otherwise their values differ at every point of Π outside a set of measure zero.*
- (ii) *For every nonzero algebraic γ , $LO(G; 0, 0, \gamma) = LO(H; 0, 0, \gamma)$ if and only if $n_q(G) = n_q(H)$ for all q . On any finite set of graphs the same holds for all but finitely many real γ .*
- (iii) *Let G and H be trees with distinct edge-degree-pair profiles and equal q -histograms, each having a leaf adjacent to a vertex of the same degree $d \geq 2$. Attaching a pendant path of length $L \geq 1$ at such a leaf in each produces trees with the same two properties and the same maximum degree. Consequently, for every $n \geq 13$ (and every $n \geq 16$ among trees with $\Delta \leq 4$) there are non-isomorphic trees of order n with distinct degree-pair profiles that no point of Π separates.*

Proof. (i) is immediate from (2): setting $\beta = -2\alpha$ removes the degree-sum factor; the substance of the theorem lies in (ii) and (iii). Agreement for equal histograms is immediate. If the histograms differ, at $\alpha = 0$ the difference is $\sum_q (n_q(G) - n_q(H)) e^{\gamma q}$, an exponential sum with distinct exponents and not all coefficients zero, which is not identically zero; the difference on Π is therefore a nonzero real-analytic function of (α, γ) , whose zero set has measure zero. (ii) For algebraic $\gamma \neq 0$ the exponents γq , $q \in \mathbb{Q}$, are distinct algebraic numbers, so by the Lindemann–Weierstrass theorem [3] the numbers $e^{\gamma q}$ are linearly independent over the algebraic numbers; the integer coefficients $n_q(G) - n_q(H)$ must all vanish. For real γ , a nonzero exponential sum with k distinct real exponents has at most $k - 1$ real zeros (Proposition 3), and a finite set of graphs gives finitely many such sums. (iii) The attachment changes the profile of each tree by the same vector, $-(1, d) + (2, d) + (L - 1)(2, 2) + (1, 2)$, so distinct profiles stay distinct, equal histograms stay equal, and the new or changed vertices have degree at most 2, so the maximum degree is unchanged when it is at least

2. The order-13 pair of Section 4.2 has a common leaf-neighbour degree $d = 3$, and the order-16 pair with $\Delta \leq 4$, $\{(1, 2)^2, (1, 4)^8, (2, 4)^2, (4, 4)^3\}$ and $\{(1, 4)^8, (2, 2)^3, (2, 4)^4\}$, has $d = 4$; this gives every larger order. ■

Theorem 2 is as much a limitation result as a characterisation. By exhaustive enumeration (orders 7–17; orders below 7 are trivial), q -histograms coincide with degree-pair profiles for all trees of order at most 12 and for trees with $\Delta \leq 4$ of order at most 15, so the pure- γ points attain the degree-pair floor exactly up to those orders and, by part (iii), at no larger order. Theorem 2 is consistent with the tie of GA , AG and the pure- γ points on the trees of order 10 (Section 4.2): all lie on Π , so none can separate more than the q -histograms (that they separate all of them there is a computational fact). It also shows the limits of the pure- γ line: at orders 13–17, the orders enumerated, generic points off Π (Proposition 7) and the Randić index (which itself leaves the floor only at order 14) separate more trees than any point of Π . In the other direction, GA , whose values are sums of square roots, merges two distinct q -histograms among trees first at order 17 (exact witness: $\{(1, 5)^{10}, (2, 2)^2, (5, 5)^2, (2, 5), (1, 2)\}$ and $\{(4, 5)^3, (1, 4)^5, (1, 5)^6, (2, 5), (1, 2)\}$ have equal GA but different q -histograms), where the pure- γ points, by part (ii), still separate all histograms. That GA depends only on the degree ratio is well known; the content here is the exact ceiling and the colliding families.

Along the γ axis the number of times two graphs can exchange order is bounded by a classical rule of signs.

Proposition 3 (γ -crossings). *Fix (α, β) and graphs G, H , and let $q_1 < \dots < q_r$ be the distinct imbalances of the degree pairs occurring in G or H . Write $D(\gamma) = LO(G; \alpha, \beta, \gamma) - LO(H; \alpha, \beta, \gamma) = \sum_{k=1}^r c_k e^{\gamma q_k}$ with $c_k = \sum_{q_{ij}=q_k} (m_{ij}(G) - m_{ij}(H))(ij)^\alpha (i+j)^\beta$, and let V be the number of sign changes in $(c_1, \dots, c_r)$ after zero terms are removed. If $D \not\equiv 0$, then D has at most $V \leq r - 1$ real zeros counted with multiplicity, and their number has the parity of V . In particular, for graphs with $\Delta \leq 4$, where the possible imbalances are $0, \frac{1}{7}, \frac{1}{5}, \frac{1}{3}, \frac{1}{2}, \frac{3}{5}$, two graphs exchange order at most five times as γ ranges over $\mathbb{R}$, for every (α, β) .*

Proof. With $x = e^\gamma > 0$, D becomes the generalised polynomial $\sum_k c_k x^{q_k}$

with distinct real exponents, to which Laguerre's extension of Descartes' rule of signs applies [17]: the number of positive zeros, with multiplicity, is at most V and has its parity. The parity statement also follows from the signs of D as $\gamma \rightarrow \mp\infty$, which are those of the first and last nonzero c_k (by the termwise argument of Proposition 5, applied to D). ■

The hypothesis $D \neq 0$ excludes in particular graphs with equal degree-pair profiles, which are tied for every γ . The sign-change bound V can be attained: two trees of order 12 with maximum degree 6 and eight distinct imbalances, with $V = 5$, cross five times at $(\alpha, \beta) = (-1, 0)$ (near $\gamma = -17.2, -12.0, -2.0, 2.7$ and 31.1 ; by the bound these are all its zeros). Whether five crossings are attained for $\Delta \leq 4$ is open. The proposition concerns the γ axis only: along other directions the exponents are not the q_k and the constant five does not apply.

Finally, the per-graph identifiability noted in Remark 1 can be stated exactly. Let $R(G)$ be the set of degree pairs realised by G , $r(G)$ the number of distinct imbalances among them, and $A(G)$ the affine dimension of $\{z_{ij} : (i, j) \in R(G)\}$.

Proposition 4 (Per-graph scale-invariant directions). *(i) $A(G)$ equals the rank of the Hessian $\text{Cov}_\theta(z)$ of $\log LO_G$ at every θ , and the directions v with $LO(G; \theta + tv) = e^{ct} LO(G; \theta)$ for all t and θ form a subspace of dimension $3 - A(G)$.*

(ii) $A(G) \leq \min(|R(G)| - 1, r(G), 3)$ for every graph.

(iii) If $r(G) = 2$ with imbalances $q_1 \neq q_2$, then $v = (1, -2, c)$ with $c = [\ln(1 - q_2^2) - \ln(1 - q_1^2)] / (q_1 - q_2)$ is such a direction.

Proof. (i) is the standard minimal-representation property of exponential families [6]: $\text{Cov}_\theta(z)$ has full support on $R(G)$, so its rank is the affine dimension of the support, and $v^\top z$ is constant on $R(G)$ exactly for v orthogonal to the differences of the z_{ij} . (ii) By (2), $z_{ij} = (2s + \ln(1 - q^2) - \ln 4, s, q)$ with $s = \ln(i + j)$, so pairs with the same imbalance lie on one line parallel to $(2, 1, 0)$, and r parallel lines span an affine space of dimension at most r . (iii) $v^\top z_{ij} = \ln(1 - q_{ij}^2) - \ln 4 + c q_{ij}$ takes the same value at q_1 and q_2 by the choice of c . ■

Equality holds in (ii) for every set of admissible pairs with $\Delta \leq 6$ (by exhaustive enumeration), hence for all molecular graphs. It fails from $\Delta = 7$: the single violating set of at most four pairs there is $\{(1, 7), (2, 6), (3, 5), (4, 4)\}$, whose degree sums all equal 8 (a constant degree sum makes $\ln(i + j)$ constant on the set, so $A \leq 2$, while the bound equals 3 as soon as the set has at least four pairs and three imbalances); a connected graph all of whose edges have the same degree sum s realises only one pair (each neighbour of a vertex of degree d then has degree $s - d$, so by connectivity only the pair $\{d, s - d\}$ occurs), hence no connected graph has this set as its pair set. For example, the spider with four legs of length three realises the pairs $(2, 4)$, $(2, 2)$ and $(1, 2)$, which have only two imbalances ($\frac{1}{3}$ and 0); on it, γ is confounded with (α, β) along the direction of part (iii). For a QSPR dataset the relevant set is the union of the pairs realised by its molecules, since a direction along which every molecule's index is rescaled by the same factor is invisible to any correlation or regression on the dataset (this concerns identifiability of θ from the index values on the given set of graphs, not of a fitted regression model); on the octanes this union contains nine of the ten admissible pairs and its affine dimension is 3, so no such direction exists.

At the two ends of the γ axis the family behaves as follows; this is used in the proof of Proposition 3. Routine termwise bounds in (m, Δ, δ) , a Cauchy–Schwarz interpolation bound and a uniform ratio bound are collected in Supplementary Section S9.

Proposition 5. *At $\gamma = 0$, $LO(G; \alpha, \beta, 0)$ coincides with the two-parameter (α, β) degree-based index $\sum_{uv \in E(G)} (d_u d_v)^\alpha (d_u + d_v)^\beta$. Let $E_{\max}(G)$ denote the set of edges realising $\text{imb}_{\max}(G) = \max_{uv} \text{imb}(d_u, d_v)$ and $E_{\min}(G)$ the set realising $\text{imb}_{\min}(G) = \min_{uv} \text{imb}(d_u, d_v)$. Then as $\gamma \rightarrow +\infty$,*

$$\frac{LO(G; \alpha, \beta, \gamma)}{e^{\gamma \text{imb}_{\max}(G)}} \longrightarrow \sum_{uv \in E_{\max}(G)} (d_u d_v)^\alpha (d_u + d_v)^\beta,$$

and as $\gamma \rightarrow -\infty$,

$$LO(G; \alpha, \beta, \gamma) / e^{\gamma \text{imb}_{\min}(G)} \longrightarrow \sum_{uv \in E_{\min}(G)} (d_u d_v)^\alpha (d_u + d_v)^\beta.$$

Proof. At $\gamma = 0$ the exponential factor is 1 on every edge. With $\mu(G) := \text{imb}_{\max}(G)$ and $\varepsilon_{uv} := \mu(G) - \text{imb}(d_u, d_v) \geq 0$, $LO(G; \alpha, \beta, \gamma) / e^{\gamma\mu(G)} = \sum_{uv} (d_u d_v)^\alpha (d_u + d_v)^\beta e^{-\gamma\varepsilon_{uv}}$; the summands over $E_{\max}(G)$ ($\varepsilon_{uv} = 0$) do not depend on γ , and the others ($\varepsilon_{uv} > 0$) tend to 0 as $\gamma \rightarrow +\infty$, termwise since $E(G)$ is finite. The case $\gamma \rightarrow -\infty$ is dual. ■

4 Discrimination and the degree-pair information ceiling

4.1 The degree-pair ceiling

The *ceiling* of this subsection and the *floor* of the next are the same limit seen from two sides: no vertex-degree-based index can separate graphs with equal degree-pair counts, so the number of distinct degree-pair profiles bounds the number of distinct values (equivalently, the minimum attainable degeneracy).

Proposition 6 (Degree-pair information ceiling). *If two graphs G and H have identical unordered edge-degree-pair count vectors, $m_{ij}(G) = m_{ij}(H)$ for all $i \leq j$, then $LO(G; \theta) = LO(H; \theta)$ for every $\theta \in \mathbb{R}^3$, and more generally $TI(G) = TI(H)$ for every vertex-degree-based index TI . Among the 18 octane isomers exactly 16 distinct count vectors occur: the pairs $\{3\text{-methylheptane}, 4\text{-methylheptane}\}$ and $\{3,4\text{-dimethylhexane}, 3\text{-ethyl-2-methylpentane}\}$ share their count vectors while differing in measured properties (Table 1), so every vertex-degree-based descriptor, tuned or not, carries a nonzero irreducible error on this benchmark.*

Proof. By Definition 1, $LO(G; \theta)$ depends on G only through the multiset of unordered edge degree pairs, i.e. through $(m_{ij}(G))_{i \leq j}$; the same holds for every vertex-degree-based index [26]. The counts for the 18 octane isomers are computed and cross-checked in the reproducibility package; both collision pairs have their common count vectors listed in Table 1. ■

The ceiling is tight in the following sense: distinct count vectors are separated by the family at almost every parameter choice.

Proposition 7 (Generic discrimination of distinct profiles). *Fix $\Delta \geq 1$ and let $m \neq m'$ be two distinct edge-degree-pair count vectors supported on the admissible pairs P_Δ . Then $D(\theta) = \sum_{(i,j) \in P_\Delta} (m_{ij} - m'_{ij}) e^{\theta^\top z_{ij}}$ is a real-analytic function of θ that is not identically zero, and its zero set has Lebesgue measure zero in $\mathbb{R}^3$. Consequently, any two graphs with distinct count vectors are distinguished by $LO(\cdot; \theta)$ for almost every $\theta \in \mathbb{R}^3$; only graphs with identical count vectors (Proposition 6) are indistinguishable for all θ .*

Proof. The map $(i, j) \mapsto z_{ij}$ is injective on P_Δ , since $\ln(ij)$ and $\ln(i + j)$ recover the product and the sum, which determine the unordered pair. Choose $v \in \mathbb{R}^3$ such that the inner products $v^\top z_{ij}$ are pairwise distinct (this excludes finitely many hyperplanes of v 's). Along the ray $\theta = tv$, $D(tv) = \sum_k c_k e^{t\lambda_k}$ with distinct exponents λ_k and coefficients $c_k = m_{i_k j_k} - m'_{i_k j_k}$, not all zero; such an exponential sum vanishes identically only if all $c_k = 0$, so $D \not\equiv 0$ on the ray and hence on $\mathbb{R}^3$. D is a finite sum of exponentials of linear functionals, hence real-analytic on $\mathbb{R}^3$, and the zero set of a nonzero real-analytic function has Lebesgue measure zero. ■

The proof uses only the injectivity of $(i, j) \mapsto (\ln(ij), \ln(i + j))$, so the same conclusion already holds for the parent family $M_{\alpha, \beta}$ on the (α, β) -plane. Proposition 7 is therefore a property the Loyola family inherits, not an advantage conferred by γ . Likewise, since $q_{ij} = \sqrt{1 - 4ij/(i + j)^2}$ is a function of the pair, the imbalance coordinate adds no graph information beyond the edge-degree-pair counts (every vertex-degree-based index is a functional of those counts [26]); what γ adds is the new functional direction of Lemma 1, i.e. a different weighting of the same information.

A corollary is a *span certificate*: on graphs of maximum degree four, any ten degree-based indices whose weight vectors $(f(i, j))_{i \leq j \leq 4}$ are linearly independent span the ten-dimensional count space, so every bond-incident-degree index — the Loyola family at every parameter value included — is an exact linear combination of such a baseline and adds no linear information beyond it for any target. The present paper is a case study of this statement: it asks what a parametric family can still offer when it cannot

add linear information, and finds interpretability and analytic structure (Section 5), not prediction.

Table 1. The two degree-pair collision pairs among the 18 octane isomers. Each pair shares its complete edge-degree-pair count vector (shown as multiplicities of the unordered pairs), hence is indistinguishable by every vertex-degree-based index for all parameter values, yet differs in the measured properties.

Isomer	T_B	ΔH_f	ΔH_{vap}	S	ω
<i>shared count vector</i> 2(1, 2), 1(1, 3), 2(2, 2), 2(2, 3):					
3-methylheptane	118.9	-50.82	9.52	111.26	0.371
4-methylheptane	117.7	-50.69	9.48	109.32	0.372
<i>shared count vector</i> 2(1, 2), 2(1, 3), 2(2, 3), 1(3, 3):					
3,4-dimethylhexane	117.7	-50.91	9.32	106.59	0.340
3-ethyl-2-methylpentane	115.6	-50.48	9.21	106.06	0.330

4.2 First loss of discrimination across tree orders

Degeneracy measures an index’s ability to discriminate non-isomorphic graphs [18]; lower is better. On the 106 non-isomorphic trees of order 10, with the distinct-value convention $100(1 - k/N)$ (k distinct values among $N = 106$ trees; Supplementary Section S5), the pure- γ points $LO(0, 0, 1)$ and $LO(0, 0, 2)$ attain degeneracy 25.5% (79 distinct values), tied with R , GA and AG ; since the 106 trees realise only 79 distinct edge-degree-pair count vectors, 25.5% is the minimum attainable by *any* degree-pair-based index on this set, while M_1 (83.0%) and M_2 (67.0%) are the most degenerate (Supplementary Figure S2). Repeating the computation for all trees of orders 7 through 12 and for their molecular subsets with $\Delta \leq 4$ (Supplementary Table S4), the pure- γ points attain the degree-pair-profile floor at every order in both sets; so does the Randić index (while χ falls off the floor from order 10, with 77 values against 79 profiles), so floor attainment distinguishes the pure- γ points from M_1 and M_2 but not from R . Theorem 2 turns this into an exact statement: the pure- γ points separate precisely the q -histograms, which coincide with the degree-pair profiles up to order 12 (order 15 for $\Delta \leq 4$) and not beyond. Among the trees of order 13 the profiles $\{(1, 2)^1, (1, 3)^2, (1, 6)^5, (2, 3)^2, (2, 6)^1, (3, 3)^1\}$

and $\{(1, 3)^3, (1, 6)^5, (2, 2)^1, (2, 3)^2, (3, 6)^1\}$ (exponents are edge multiplicities) share the q -histogram $\{0^1, \frac{1}{5}^2, \frac{1}{3}^1, \frac{1}{2}^3, \frac{5}{7}^5\}$. Table 2 collects the first failures; at order 14, where R falls below the floor, the pure- γ points give 1090 values, and R still attains the floor at order 13 (570 values).

Table 2. First tree order at which discrimination is lost (values counted as distinct at 11 significant digits). “Below floor”: first order with fewer distinct values than distinct edge-degree-pair profiles (the floor for every vertex-degree-based index), with (values/profiles) at that order. “Merges”: first order at which an index on Π gives equal values to two trees with different q -histograms (not applicable to R , which is not on Π). $LO(0, 0, \gamma)$: the pure- γ points $\gamma = 1, 2$. Orders below 7 not examined; “—”: not determined.

Index	all trees		trees with $\Delta \leq 4$	
	below floor	merges	below floor	merges
$LO(0, 0, \gamma)$	13 (566/570)	never ^a	16 (809/810)	never ^a
R	14 (1095/1100)	n/a ^b	> 16 ^c	n/a ^b
GA	13 (566/570) ^d	17 ^e	16 (809/810) ^d	— ^e

^a All q -histograms are separated for every nonzero algebraic γ (Theorem 2(ii)). ^b R is not on Π . ^c R attains the floor for trees with $\Delta \leq 4$ at every order up to 16, the largest examined. ^d GA lies on Π and merges no q -histograms below order 17, so there it ties the pure- γ points. ^e The witness (Section 3.1) has maximum degree 5.

Off the ratio plane the imbalance factor has a visible effect at fixed classical exponents. A point $(0, \beta, 0)$ weights an edge by its degree sum only, so two degree pairs with the same sum receive the same weight; with $\gamma \neq 0$ they are separated, because their imbalances differ. Computationally, on all trees of order 16 (4069 profiles), $LO(0, \frac{1}{2}, 0)$ and $LO(0, \frac{1}{3}, 0)$ take only 3475 and 3476 distinct values, whereas $LO(0, \frac{1}{2}, 1)$ and $LO(0, \frac{1}{3}, 1)$ separate all 4069 profiles; likewise $LO(\frac{1}{2}, 0, \cdot)$ rises from 3940 to 4067 and the Randić point $LO(-\frac{1}{2}, 0, \cdot)$ from 4007 to 4068 when γ goes from 0 to 1, while points on Π such as GA are unaffected (3996 in both cases), as Theorem 2 requires. The effect is one of repairing particular classical exponents, not of making discrimination possible at all: generic parent points such as $LO(0.3, 0.2, 0)$ already separate all 4069 profiles (Proposition 7). It is established by enumeration for orders 12–16 rather than proved; it does not translate into a predictive gain over a tuned parent on the sets and protocols of Section 5 (the sign of the change at fixed fractional exponents

depends on the property; exploratory, Supplementary Section S5).

4.3 Structure sensitivity on decane isomers

The structure-sensitivity criterion of Furtula, Gutman and Dehmer [9] (with a fingerprint-based variant due to Rakić and Furtula [27]) was implemented with the published protocol on the 75 decane isomer trees, the similar structures of a tree being those obtained by relocating a single edge within the molecular class; SS and Abr are the class means of the mean and the maximum relative change of the index over these neighbours. The implementation reproduces the published decane-class values of Barman and Das [4] (eleven of fourteen SS/Abr values exactly at the four displayed decimals, the other three within one unit in the fourth); the protocol and this control are detailed in Supplementary Section S6. Under the published desideratum (SS large, Abr small), $LO(0, 0, 2)$ has a structure sensitivity indistinguishable at three decimals from that of the hyper-Zagreb index (0.1257 against 0.1256) at a markedly smaller abruptness (0.274 against 0.313), and the sensitivity-to-abruptness ratios of the pure- γ points (0.4579 and 0.4565) are comparable to those of $H/2$, GA and R (0.448–0.451; Table 3); in view of the redundancy noted in Section 5.1, these third-decimal differences are not a ranking. Moreover, SS is not a fixed property of the family: along the pure- γ line it grows with γ (0.031, 0.062, 0.126, 0.319 at $\gamma = 0.5, 1, 2, 5$) while the ratio peaks near $\gamma = 2$ and then falls (0.427 at $\gamma = 5$); and the parameter-free aggregate $IRLA$, to which the pure- γ points reduce to first order in γ ($LO(0, 0, \gamma) = m + \frac{\gamma}{2} IRLA + O(\gamma^2)$), has a higher ratio ($SS = 0.2343$, $Abr = 0.5066$, ratio 0.4625). The favourable sensitivity–abruptness balance is therefore a property of linear imbalance weighting rather than of the exponential form, and the equality of SS with hyper-Zagreb at $\gamma = 2$ reflects the chosen value of γ ; it is a tie, not a ranking.

Table 3. Structure sensitivity SS , abruptness Abr , and their ratio on the 75 decane isomers under the published similar-structure protocol of [9] (single-edge relocation within the molecular class).

Index	SS	Abr	SS/Abr
M_1	0.0566	0.1336	0.4238
M_2	0.0922	0.2443	0.3776
HM	0.1256	0.3126	0.4017
mM_2	0.0516	0.1177	0.4384
R	0.0264	0.0588	0.4481
χ	0.0264	0.0591	0.4463
$H/2$	0.0516	0.1143	0.4514
ISI	0.0226	0.0597	0.3795
GA	0.0241	0.0535	0.4507
AG	0.0256	0.0579	0.4415
$LO(0, 0, 1)$	0.0624	0.1367	0.4565
$LO(0, 0, 2)$	0.1257	0.2745	0.4579

5 A concise QSPR diagnostic

Reporting conventions. In Tables 5–7, medians are taken over candidate-stream seeds; seed counts summarise the variability of the random search on fixed data and are not replications. All values are full-precision results rounded once, and a median of differences quoted in the text need not equal the difference of the medians shown. The narrow- and wide-box streams use the same uniform variates scaled by the half-width, so comparisons across boxes are paired.

We benchmark the Loyola family against the classical indices it reduces to on the 18 octane isomers, following the chemometric benchmark of the diminished Sombor study [22], and on the 35 nonane isomers as a replication set (models refitted on it). The comparison set is restricted to the exact reductions of Section 1 — $M_1, M_2, HM, ^mM_2, R, \chi, H/2, ISI, GA, AG$ — together with the two fixed pure- γ benchmark points $LO(0, 0, 1)$ and $LO(0, 0, 2)$ chosen for this study (the edge count $m = LO(0, 0, 0)$ is constant on the octanes and omitted); no parameter in the correlation comparison is tuned against the property data (an exploratory local-tuning check, Supplementary Section S2, did not exceed the best fixed benchmark except by a 0.001 in-sample ΔH_{vap} margin). All comparisons are descriptive

and diagnostic: on these small sets they show what imbalance information does and does not add to the parent family, not chemical predictive utility, and given the number of properties, indices, and tuning candidates examined, no confirmatory inference is claimed. Values are computed in double precision and rounded *once* for display (three decimals for correlations, Q^2 and RMSE, four for structure sensitivity), so a tabulated difference may differ by one unit in the last place from the difference of two displayed entries.

5.1 Property correlations on the octane isomers

Table 4 reports the Pearson correlation r between each index and each of the five physicochemical properties of the 18 octane isomers (boiling point T_B , enthalpy of formation ΔH_f , enthalpy of vaporization ΔH_{vap} , entropy S , acentric factor ω ; data and units in Appendix A). Boiling points, formation enthalpies and (with the exception noted below) vaporization enthalpies are traced to the NIST WebBook [20]; the acentric factors come from KDB-derived compilations (NIST does not list them); the WebBook lists a gas-phase entropy for only five of the isomers, so seven entropies are compared with the 1947 API Research Project 44 tables [30] or a compiled octane dataset and six could not be traced to a primary source (Appendix A.1); all 90 molecule-level values were audited against authoritative sources (Supplementary Section S1, with the molecule-by-molecule discussion). Three caveats remain. The 298 K vaporization enthalpy of 2,2,3,3-tetramethylbutane, a solid at 298 K (triple point 374 K), is the benchmark-compilation value 8.41 kcal mol⁻¹ (35.19 kJ mol⁻¹), matching neither NIST standard vaporization enthalpy (42.94 and 42.91 kJ mol⁻¹, about 10.26 kcal mol⁻¹), so its physical reference state is unresolved. Six gas-phase entropies could not be verified against a primary source (the 1947 API Project 44 values differ from them by up to 2.2 units; the 2,3,3-trimethylpentane value is a compiled-dataset value; Appendix A.1), and four entropies differ from a widely used compilation; substituting the compilation values changes all twelve S correlations (by up to 0.043 in $|r|$) and moves the margin between HM and M_1 at the top from 0.001 to 0.007, margins that are not meaningful at this resolution. Alternative compiled

acentric factors change several ω correlations at the third decimal (e.g. M_2 from -0.988 to -0.986) and leave the ω ranking unchanged.

Table 4. Pearson correlation r between the Loyola reductions, the fixed pure- γ benchmark points and the five physicochemical properties of the 18 octane isomers. Bold flags the largest $|r|$ per column (descriptive; margins to the runner-up are 0.001–0.032 and their paired bootstrap intervals include zero, see the text).

Index	T_B	ΔH_f	ΔH_{vap}	S	ω
$M_1 = LO(0, 1, 0)$	-0.718	-0.762	-0.935	-0.970	-0.970
$M_2 = LO(1, 0, 0)$	-0.497	-0.542	-0.811	-0.934	-0.988
$HM = LO(0, 2, 0)$	-0.654	-0.710	-0.903	-0.971	-0.982
${}^mM_2 = LO(-1, 0, 0)$	+0.855	+0.891	+0.925	+0.863	+0.794
$R = LO(-1/2, 0, 0)$	+0.819	+0.850	+0.958	+0.932	+0.898
$\chi = LO(0, -1/2, 0)$	+0.800	+0.832	+0.961	+0.947	+0.924
$H/2 = LO(0, -1, 0)$	+0.821	+0.849	+0.961	+0.932	+0.900
$ISI = LO(1, -1, 0)$	-0.005	-0.000	-0.383	-0.593	-0.738
$GA = 2 LO(1/2, -1, 0)$	+0.822	+0.858	+0.965	+0.939	+0.906
$AG = \frac{1}{2} LO(-1/2, 1, 0)$	-0.816	-0.859	-0.957	-0.938	-0.900
$LO(0, 0, 1)$	-0.828	-0.832	-0.984	-0.928	-0.929
$LO(0, 0, 2)$	-0.829	-0.846	-0.981	-0.937	-0.925

The best correlation per property is split among the reductions and the pure- γ points: ${}^mM_2 = LO(-1, 0, 0)$ is strongest on T_B and ΔH_f , $HM = LO(0, 2, 0)$ on S , $M_2 = LO(1, 0, 0)$ on ω , and the fixed (not tuned) pure- γ benchmark point $LO(0, 0, 1)$ on ΔH_{vap} ($|r| = 0.984$, with $LO(0, 0, 2)$ second at 0.981). At the exact-reduction triples the Loyola correlations coincide with the corresponding classical indices to floating-point precision, as they must. For each property a descriptive post-selection paired bootstrap interval for the observed top-two $|r|$ difference included zero (not multiplicity-adjusted; such intervals do not establish equality or equivalence), and recomputing each bolded correlation with single isomers deleted shifts $|r|$ by at most 0.027; bootstrap details are in Supplementary Section S1. The bolded entries are the largest of twelve highly correlated sample correlations on 18 molecules; picking the maximum makes them optimistic estimates of the correlation the selected descriptor would show on new molecules (a winner’s-curse selection effect). They are descriptive rankings, not tests.

On the octanes the pure- γ points are highly collinear with the classical reductions (maximum $|r|$ with a reduction equal to 0.982 for $LO(0, 0, 1)$ and 0.993 for $LO(0, 0, 2)$).

Descriptor redundancy. Fourteen of the descriptor pairs have $|r| \geq 0.99$ and the first two principal components carry 99.05% of the variance (Supplementary Section S1), so differences in the third decimal of $|r|$ between near-collinear descriptors should not be read as meaningful rankings.

The information ceiling realised on this benchmark. Proposition 6 is not hypothetical on these data: the 18 isomers realise only 16 distinct edge-degree-pair count vectors, and the two collision pairs of Table 1 are indistinguishable by *every* vertex-degree-based index at *every* parameter choice, while their measured properties differ (by up to 1.2 °C in T_B within the first pair and 2.1 °C within the second; the entropy differences rest partly on values that could not be verified against a primary source). Every correlation in Table 4, and every tuned variant in the sections below, operates above this irreducible floor.

5.2 Freeing γ gives no consistent gain once the parent is not truncated

Given identical search budgets, does freeing γ improve out-of-sample prediction beyond an optimized parent $M_{\alpha,\beta}$? In a fully nested leave-one-out design (details in Supplementary Section S3), for each property and each outer fold, candidate parameter vectors drawn uniformly per coordinate from a search box (triples (α, β, γ) for the Loyola model, pairs (α, β) with $\gamma = 0$ for the parent; identical budget) are scored on the training isomers only by *inner* leave-one-out root-mean-square error of the one-descriptor linear regression; the best candidate is refit and the held-out isomer predicted, so no quantity computed on the held-out isomer enters selection or fitting. In the box $(-2, 2)$ used first, freeing γ appeared to help the vaporization enthalpy (Supplementary Table S3): over one hundred candidate streams it improved nested predictive performance for ΔH_{vap} in every seed (100/100 at budgets 200 and 500; median $\Delta Q^2 = +0.069$ and

+0.068), while it usually degraded ΔH_f and gave mixed or slightly negative results for the other properties (with 2,2,3,3-tetramethylbutane excluded the count falls to 93/100 and 96/100; Supplementary Section S3). These counts describe optimizer variance on one fixed set of 18 molecules and carry no inferential weight. Selection also varies across folds: for ΔH_f the three-parameter search chose three distinct triples over the 18 folds, whereas for ΔH_{vap} it chose the same triple in every fold (Supplementary Section S3), so the nested Q^2 evaluates the selection-plus-fit procedure, not one fitted model. The counts also hide a boundary effect: for ΔH_{vap} the parent chose $(\alpha, \beta) = (1.021, -1.993)$, on the boundary of the box, in 16 of the 18 folds.

These comparisons share one design choice that is decisive: the box $(-2, 2)$, which the nonane pre-registration also fixed. Because $\ln(ij) = 2\ln(i + j) + \ln(1 - q^2) - \ln 4$ (equation (2)), the parent family reaches imbalance information through $(1 - q^2)^\alpha$ along the direction $\beta \approx -2\alpha$, but it needs large exponents to weight it strongly, and the box truncates exactly that direction. To test this, the matched comparison was repeated (this analysis was not pre-registered) with 2000 candidates per model, seeds 0–49, and boxes of half-width 2 and 12 for both models (Table 5). In the box of half-width 12 the parent’s selections are interior in more than 90% of folds for every property, and the vaporization-enthalpy gain shrinks to about zero: a hybrid control that widens only (α, β) gives median $\Delta Q^2 = +0.004$ on the octanes (28 of 50 seeds) and -0.002 on the nonanes (24 of 50), and widening all three coordinates gives -0.010 and -0.016 . On the other properties no advantage is consistent across boxes: under the hybrid control the Loyola model is ahead for octane S (38 of 50 seeds) and nonane T_B (31 of 50), but behind for octane T_B , ΔH_f and ω , and the wide box itself lowers the parent’s Q^2 for S and T_B . The vaporization-enthalpy gains reported above are therefore consistent with a truncation effect rather than with information that the parent lacks: most of the change comes from the parent improving in the wide box ($0.887 \rightarrow 0.942$ on the octanes), the rest from the three-dimensional search being slightly less efficient there ($0.957 \rightarrow 0.946$ for the hybrid control). The economy that remains belongs to linear imbalance weighting rather than to γ : the

fixed point $LO(0,0,1)$ and the parameter-free *IRLA* approach what the parent reaches only near $(\alpha, \beta) \approx (4.5, -9)$ ($Q^2 = 0.957$ and 0.948 against 0.949 there, on the octanes).

Table 5. Sensitivity of the matched comparison to the search box (octanes: oct., $n = 18$; nonanes: non.). Edge: share of outer folds in which the parent’s selection lies within 10% of the boundary of the box of the stated half-width. Medians of Q^2 over seeds 0–49 at 2000 candidates per model, and the number of seeds (of 50) in which LO beats GM (half-width 2) or LO_h beats GM (half-width 12). LO_h is a hybrid control with (α, β) in the wide box and γ in $(-2, 2)$, which avoids diluting the Loyola search over a wide γ range.

Set, prop.	half-width 2				half-width 12				
	Edge	GM	LO	>	Edge	GM	LO	LO_h	>
oct. T_B	69%	0.665	0.730	36	2%	0.606	0.495	0.544	21
oct. ΔH_f	52%	0.821	0.769	11	0%	0.820	0.670	0.761	10
oct. ΔH_{vap}	97%	0.887	0.957	50	3%	0.942	0.934	0.946	28
oct. S	85%	0.904	0.891	11	4%	0.842	0.838	0.867	38
oct. ω	0%	0.979	0.974	10	0%	0.979	0.938	0.951	7
non. T_B	61%	0.576	0.601	30	0%	0.524	0.392	0.577	31
non. ΔH_{vap}	93%	0.855	0.895	49	9%	0.892	0.881	0.889	24

The honest summary is therefore that, under these protocols, tuning γ yields no demonstrated predictive advantage over a parent model that is evaluated over the wider search box. Equal candidate budgets do not guarantee equally thorough search in two and three dimensions; the hybrid control, which keeps γ in a narrow range, reduces this asymmetry but does not remove it, and a more exhaustive three-dimensional search could in principle find a better Loyola point. Its value lies in the structural results of Section 3 and in the comparison with linear imbalance weighting documented in Section 5.3.

5.3 Replication on the nonane isomers and stronger baselines

Under a protocol committed to the reproducibility package before any nonane value was collected, the identical nested design was applied to the 35 constitutional nonane isomers, with boiling points (35 values: 20

NIST averages, 5 single determinations and 10 most recent determinations selected under the protocol’s Deviation D1) and standard vaporization enthalpies (34 values) from the NIST WebBook [20]; only 4 of the 34 vaporization enthalpies are calorimetric determinations (one more is a NIST average) and 29 come from two compilations [19,34] (NIST attributes the 25 handbook values to a 1972 review of that handbook, listed as “Reid, 1972” in the provenance file), so agreement with them measures consistency with the compiled values rather than independent experimental validation; within-fold baselines are in Table 6. The pre-registered verdicts are that the γ effect *replicates* for ΔH_{vap} (compilation values; LO better than GM in 95/100 and 98/100 seeds, median $\Delta Q^2 = +0.048$ and $+0.053$) and is *mixed* for T_B (58/100 and 63/100). The pre-registered protocol, however, fixed the box of half-width 2, which binds the parent (Table 5); in a box that does not, the nonane gain disappears (median $\Delta Q^2 = -0.002$ under the hybrid control), and the pre-registered verdict is reported as obtained, with this deviation recorded. The fixed point $LO(0, 0, 1)$, which involves no tuning at all, matches or beats the tuned Loyola model on both sets (0.957 and 0.903 against medians 0.953 and 0.900). It is closely related to *IRLA*: $LO(G; 0, 0, \gamma) = m + \frac{\gamma}{2} IRLA(G) + O(\gamma^2)$ as $\gamma \rightarrow 0$ (at $\gamma = 1$ higher moments of the imbalance remain, and trees with equal *IRLA* can differ in $LO(0, 0, 1)$), the correlation between the two is 0.996 on both sets, and *IRLA* itself comes within 0.003 of the median Loyola model on the nonanes (0.897 against 0.900), so what matters for this property is a term linear in the imbalance, not the tuned exponential. Ridge regression on the full degree-pair count vector predicts the nonanes better than every index model ($Q^2 = 0.927$ for ΔH_{vap} , 0.682 for T_B), consistent with Proposition 6 and the remark after Proposition 7: every index in the family is a one-dimensional reweighting of the degree-pair counts, and the imbalance coordinate re-weights that information rather than adding to it. Protocol details, an exploratory transfer analysis and a post hoc molecule bootstrap conditional on the fitted predictions, which therefore omits refitting and selection uncertainty (its 95% interval for LO minus GM on nonane ΔH_{vap} , $[-0.006, +0.113]$ at budget 200, includes zero) are in Supplementary Section S4.

Table 6. Nested leave-one-out Q^2 on the octanes (oct., $n = 18$) and the nonane replication set (non., $n = 35$ for T_B , 34 for ΔH_{vap}). Mean: training-fold mean; Class.: best of the ten classical indices, selected inside each fold; IRLA: one-descriptor model on *IRLA*; Ridge: ridge regression on the edge-degree-pair counts; LO_1 : the fixed, untuned point $\text{LO}(0, 0, 1)$; GM, LO: median of Q^2 over seeds 0–99 at budget 200 in the box of half-width 2 (see Table 5 for wider boxes); last column: seeds in which LO beat GM at budgets 200/500.

Set, property	Mean	Class.	IRLA	Ridge	LO_1	GM	LO	LO>GM
oct. T_B	−0.121	0.593	0.585	0.344	0.591	0.662	0.652	53/64
oct. ΔH_f	−0.121	0.746	0.593	0.654	0.639	0.831	0.689	14/24
oct. ΔH_{vap}	−0.121	0.884	0.948	0.954	0.957	0.888	0.953	100/100
oct. S	−0.121	0.905	0.733	0.721	0.785	0.904	0.889	34/31
oct. ω	−0.121	0.971	0.810	0.851	0.823	0.979	0.970	26/28
non. T_B	−0.060	0.502	0.400	0.682	0.409	0.577	0.586	58/63
non. ΔH_{vap}	−0.062	0.857	0.897	0.927	0.903	0.853	0.900	95/98

5.4 Measured boiling points: decanes and pooled C6–C10

Because measured vaporization enthalpies are too scarce for a larger test (counting carbon skeletons with at least one calorimetric standard-state 298 K determination, after resolving NIST averaged entries against their individual measurements, NIST lists only 25 acyclic alkane skeletons outside C_8 and C_9 , and one of the 75 decanes), two further tests used measured boiling points, under a protocol committed to the repository before any model was fitted (the NIST pages had been archived two days earlier during a data-availability audit, which counted available values only). Boiling points were taken from the NIST WebBook [20] by a fixed rule (the NIST average, or else the median of non-compilation determinations if they agree within 3 K; otherwise the molecule is excluded), giving all hexanes, heptanes and octanes, 34 of the 35 nonanes (one has two NIST entries with the same InChI whose boiling points differ by 6.4 K) and 34 of the 75 decanes (31 have no NIST boiling point and 10 have determinations more than 3 K apart; for 14 of the 34 included decanes NIST lists a single non-compilation determination, so the agreement rule does not apply to them). Because the same rule is applied to every molecule, the octane boiling points in the

pooled set can differ from those of Table 8 by up to 0.5 °C (for example 2,4-dimethylhexane, 108.9 against 109.4 °C, a documented source variation). For the same reason, eight of the pooled nonane boiling points differ from the replication-set values of Section 5.3 by 0.1–0.9 °C: the nonane protocol took the most recent determination where NIST gives no average, whereas this rule takes the median of all non-compilation determinations. The included and excluded decanes do not differ detectably in branching or imbalance (numbers of tertiary and quaternary carbons and of methyl groups, Wiener index, *IRLA*, *LO*(0,0,1) and *R*; two-sided permutation tests, all $p \geq 0.10$), although with 34 and 41 molecules such tests can rule out only large differences. Test A evaluates the models on the decanes as a new cohort, refitting and reselecting inside each leave-one-out fold (it is not a frozen octane-trained model applied to decanes); Test B pools all 100 molecules and adds the carbon number n_C as a covariate, so that each descriptor is judged on branching beyond size. Both use the non-truncating design of Section 5.2: the parent is searched over $(\alpha, \beta) \in (-12, 12)^2$ and the Loyola model over the same box with $\gamma \in (-2, 2)$, with 2000 candidates and seeds 0–49, and the pre-registered criterion for a γ effect required at least 40 wins in 50 seeds and a molecule-bootstrap interval excluding zero (Table 7). The rule is one-sided: a negative difference also returns “no evidence”, so the verdict never reads as evidence that γ hurts.

Table 7. Measured boiling points (nested leave-one-out Q^2). Test A: decane cohort, refitted within folds; Test B: pooled C6–C10 with the carbon number n_C in every model (Class., *IRLA*, LO₁: n_C plus that descriptor). Base: training-fold mean (Test A) or n_C alone (Test B); Class.: best classical index chosen in each fold; LO₁: fixed *LO*(0,0,1); Ridge: ridge regression on the degree-pair counts; GM, LO: medians over seeds 0–49 in the non-truncating boxes; ΔQ^2 : median of LO minus GM; last column: seeds (of 50) in which LO beats GM.

Test	Base	Class.	<i>IRLA</i>	LO ₁	Ridge	GM	LO	ΔQ^2	>
decanes ($n = 34$)	−0.062	0.176	0.167	0.149	0.860	0.514	0.406	−0.072	15
C6–C10, with n_C ($n = 100$)	0.938	0.967	0.963	0.963	0.991	0.977	0.977	−0.000	25

Both pre-registered verdicts are negative: under these protocols, freeing γ shows no demonstrated advantage for boiling points, either on the decane cohort (median $\Delta Q^2 = -0.072$, LO ahead in 15 of 50 seeds, 95% interval

$[-0.156, +0.001]$) or in the pooled size-adjusted set $(-0.000, 25 \text{ of } 50, [-0.003, +0.002])$. In the original box of half-width 2, reported as the pre-registration requires, the two tuned models are level on the decanes (medians 0.469 and 0.465) and the Loyola model is marginally ahead on the pooled set (0.980 against 0.976), so the decane verdict does not depend on the box; the lower decane Q^2 of the hybrid control (0.406 against 0.465 in the narrow box) reflects the cost of a three-dimensional search over a wide box rather than a penalty for γ . The pooled cohort was corrected after an external audit found that one nonane’s second NIST entry had been skipped (Deviation D5 in the repository; pooling grouped pages also moved one heptane value by 0.2°C); on the uncorrected cohort of 101 molecules the same test gave $-0.000, 24 \text{ of } 50, [-0.003, +0.002]$, so the correction changes no conclusion. The seed counts measure the variability of the random search on fixed data, not independent replications, and the intervals come from a bootstrap over molecules conditional on the fitted predictions, so they do not include the uncertainty of refitting and model selection. The baselines show where the information is. Ridge regression on the ten degree-pair counts reaches $Q^2 = 0.860$ on the decanes, where every single index stays between 0.15 and 0.51, and 0.991 on the pooled set; a permutation check on the decanes (200 random permutations of the boiling points) gives it a median Q^2 of -0.09 , so the gap is not an artefact of the cross-validation procedure itself, although a permutation test cannot exclude every possible form of leakage. Branching effects on the boiling point are thus spread over several degree-pair counts in a way that no one-dimensional summary of the family, with or without γ , recovers. These conclusions concern acyclic alkanes, i.e. closely related hydrocarbons without rings or heteroatoms; they are the primary predictive evidence of this paper, with the vaporization-enthalpy analyses of Sections 5.2 and 5.3 as secondary diagnostics. Data, rule, exclusions and scripts are in the repository.

6 Conclusion

The Loyola family extends the Gutman–Milovanović family $M_{\alpha,\beta}$ [14, 21] by an exponential imbalance factor and reduces to it at $\gamma = 0$. Its structural content is exact: the imbalance direction is affinely independent of the two parent directions for $\Delta \geq 3$ (a class-level statement, Remark 1); $\log LO$ is globally convex; the pure- γ line discriminates exactly the histogram of edge imbalances and loses degree-pair information from tree order 13 (order 16 for $\Delta \leq 4$); two graphs with maximum degree at most 4 (all alkane skeletons) exchange order at most five times along the γ axis; and routine termwise bounds (Supplementary Section S9) extend parent inequalities to $\gamma \neq 0$. Generic discrimination is inherited from the parent, and the imbalance coordinate re-weights degree-pair information without adding to it.

Chemometrically, the evidence is diagnostic: every vertex-degree-based index on the octanes operates above an irreducible floor set by two degree-pair collision pairs, and the apparent vaporization-enthalpy gain from freeing γ — seen in every candidate stream of the octane sweep (93–96 of 100 without 2,2,3,3-tetramethylbutane) and meeting the pre-registered optimizer-stability criterion on the 34 nonanes (mostly compilation values) — disappears once the parent family is searched over a box that does not truncate it (a post hoc analysis, Table 5). Tuning γ thus yields no demonstrated predictive advantage under the protocols used here, which does not exclude benefits on other properties, compound classes or search designs; on vaporization enthalpy the untuned point $LO(0, 0, 1)$, highly correlated with *IRLA*, matches the tuned models (nested Q^2 0.903 against medians 0.900–0.902 on the nonanes), and ridge regression on all degree-pair counts predicts both nonane properties better than every fixed index and than the median tuned GM and LO models. Pre-registered tests on measured boiling points complement this with a new cohort and a larger pooled set: no demonstrated benefit from γ on the 34 decanes or the 100 pooled C6–C10 alkanes adjusted for size, with ridge on the degree-pair counts far ahead of every single index on the decanes and ahead on the pooled set (Table 7). The compactness of $LO(0, 0, 1)$ belongs to linear imbalance

weighting and is shared by the parameter-free *IRLA*; what the third coordinate itself offers is an interpretable, analytically tractable direction and an exact account of what the imbalance direction can and cannot resolve; open problems are listed in Supplementary Section S8.

Reproducibility. Data, scripts and verifiers that recompute every tabulated value are at <https://github.com/Singati2/LOYOLA-PAPER>; the nonane and boiling-point protocols were committed there before the corresponding models were fitted, and scripts reproduce every structural count, witness and auxiliary value quoted in the text. The termwise bounds of Supplementary Section S9, the convexity part of Theorem 1, the rank-4 statement of Lemma 1 for $\Delta \geq 3$, and the order-13 profile collision of Section 4.2 have additionally been machine-checked in Lean 4 with Mathlib (graphs modelled by their multisets of edge degree pairs; equality characterizations not formalized); its scope and encoding are described in Supplementary Section S7, and the formalization is in the repository.

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A Octane isomer property data

For reproducibility, Table 8 lists the full 18-isomer dataset used in Section 5. Units: T_B in $^{\circ}\text{C}$; ΔH_f and ΔH_{vap} in kcal mol^{-1} (ΔH_{vap} at 298 K); S in $\text{cal mol}^{-1}\text{K}^{-1}$; ω dimensionless. The ΔH_{vap} values of 3,3-dimethylhexane (8.97), 3-ethyl-3-methylpentane (9.08), 2,2,3-trimethylpentane (8.83) and 2,3,3-trimethylpentane (8.90) are values consistent with the NIST WebBook determinations (see Supplementary Section S1 for the exact-versus-within-uncertainty status of each). The ΔH_{vap} entry of 2,2,3,3-tetramethylbutane is a benchmark-compilation value whose physical reference state is unresolved (Section 5.1). The S value of 2,3,3-trimethylpentane (102.06) is a compiled-dataset value (Appendix A.1).

A.1 Data quality

The open provenance items of Table 8 (unverified entropies, the vaporization enthalpy of 2,2,3,3-tetramethylbutane, the corrected transcription of

the 2,3,3-trimethylpentane entropy and the alternative compiled values, with their effect on Table 4) are collected in Supplementary Section S10; none of them enters the pre-registered tests of Sections 5.3 and 5.4.

Table 8. Physicochemical properties of the 18 octane isomers.

Isomer	T_B	ΔH_f	ΔH_{vap}	S	ω
<i>n</i> -octane	125.6	−49.82	9.92	111.55	0.398
2-methylheptane	117.6	−51.50	9.48	109.84	0.378
3-methylheptane	118.9	−50.82	9.52	111.26	0.371
4-methylheptane	117.7	−50.69	9.48	109.32	0.372
2,2-dimethylhexane	106.8	−53.71	8.92	103.13	0.339
2,3-dimethylhexane	115.6	−51.13	9.27	108.02	0.348
2,4-dimethylhexane	109.4	−52.44	9.03	106.98	0.344
2,5-dimethylhexane	109.1	−53.21	9.05	105.72	0.357
3,3-dimethylhexane	111.9	−52.61	8.97	104.74	0.322
3,4-dimethylhexane	117.7	−50.91	9.32	106.59	0.340
3-ethyl-2-methylpentane	115.6	−50.48	9.21	106.06	0.330
3-ethyl-3-methylpentane	118.3	−51.38	9.08	101.48	0.302
3-ethylhexane	118.5	−50.40	9.48	109.43	0.362
2,2,3-trimethylpentane	109.8	−52.61	8.83	101.31	0.300
2,2,4-trimethylpentane	99.2	−53.57	8.40	101.81	0.305
2,3,3-trimethylpentane	114.8	−51.73	8.90	102.06	0.291
2,3,4-trimethylpentane	113.5	−51.97	9.01	102.39	0.317
2,2,3,3-tetramethylbutane	106.5	−53.99	8.41	93.06	0.247

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